In Pakistan, a lot of players indeed debut early, in their teens, and never even finish high school or attend college before turning into full-time cricketers. (Not that we have many good high schools or colleges left, to begin with.) While that itself is unfortunate, what is also responsible is the way our cricketing ecosystem has developed over the years – there's the absence of university cricket, and first-class cricket is on the decline. Thus, it's the cricket board's job to take a young talent and groom and guide him towards a bigger, more mature career in the game. If that includes making one enrol for classes in English, or public relations, or even learn how to dress up and eat with a knife and fork, so be it. Some kid from central Punjab who's breaking records at seventeen, and is a natural, must be allowed to play. At the same time, he should also be prepared and made ready for the real world, in actual cricket academies, not just left out in the wild.

Although senior players in the team have a lot to do with grooming youngsters, ultimately it's the board's job to make a proper gentleman out of a random rising star. This concept is huge in American sports. There's financial management: what you could do with all this money you're now making. There is ethical management: what to say or not to say and how to behave now that you're a public figure. In the US, sportspersons are considered assets. In Pakistan, they are left to fend for themselves and eventually written off as liabilities. What a shame.

The 2010 spot-fixing scandal tainted us all. It also created a trust deficit. The next time we were on the field playing a game and a player dropped a catch or let go of an easy wicket or even bowled a wide ball, I would have to hold myself back to not doubt him. But after the Butt–Asif–Amir scandal, we all fought really hard to win each other's trust and respect again.

We consolidated as a unit when we started asking tough questions from each other: why would you throw away your respect by being greedy when you already make enough money? Why would you disrespect your mates, your team and your country when that was all you had? These questions had no simple answers.

But we found them. And we fought back.

Well, at least some of us did.